

## Costanza World 4-Squares Champion

Many know Northbridge as a growing suburban town nestled within the Blackstone Valley in Worcester County. What some may not know is its long and storied history with the game, or some may say "sport" of



4-Squares. No one knows this better than the newly crowned World 4-Squares Champion, Northbridge's own, Eric Costanza.

What is 4-Squares? 4-Squares is played on a square court divided into four evenly sized quadrants. Without getting into the complex rules, players use a ball very similar to a kickball to bounce/strike with their hands to each other's dedicated squares until the play results in someone getting "out." It is very similar to tennis minus the racket and net but on a much smaller court and with four competitors. Though 4-Squares is very common for elementary school age children, when played at a high level, it takes incredible athleticism, strategy and skill to compete and succeed.

Costanza, 41, and a former two-sport star within the Northbridge High School class of 1999, explains how his love of 4-Squares began. "I grew up right next to the former Riverside Park (which is now the site of the new

Northbridge Fire Station) and as a kid I participated within the parks & recreation program where we would play 4-Squares almost all day throughout the summers. It was more than just a game. We became a little summertime family by bonding over the laughs and fun that this sport provided."

House of Representatives from the 10th Worcester District, David Muradian, who attended the parks programs with Costanza explains, "As a child who grew up at the Northbridge Parks & Recreation summer program, I can remember the eagerness and excitement of learning 4-Squares, and then playing other parks in friendly competitions. Northbridge has always had great athletes, which is why it is no surprise to me

that Eric found success even after all these years." Northbridge's unique villages played a key part into the adoption of the success the kids and teenagers gained from playing as they were motivated to defeat their fellow village counterparts. At the conclusion of each summer, everyone's skills were put to the test in a town-wide 4-Squares Tournament. Costanza, who was a 7-time town champion says, "The tournament eventually took a life of its own and the sheer talent sprinkled all over Northbridge and the surrounding towns made for a truly amazing sporting event."

After spending time in his late teens and early 20's as a Park Instructor guiding and teaching kids the knowledge he learned within 4-Squares, Costanza went on to graduate from Assumption University in Worcester. This is when he tabbed his love for 4-Squares to focus on his career and building a family. Costanza is a Project Manager at a Benefits & Technology Company, married for 13 years and has three children when he spends most of his time being a Dad and husband.

The story doesn't end here. In late 2019, at 38 years old, Costanza started getting the itch to get back into the sport he loved. After a quick Google search, he stumbled across the World 4-Squares Championships which take place annually in the beautiful lake region of Bridgton, Maine. The competition draws athletes from all over the US and Canada as well as competitors from Israel to Bermuda. This was the spark that Costanza needed to ignite his passion. However, a global pandemic forced the event to be cancelled from 2020-2022. During this time, Costanza started a local group called "The Ultimate 4-Squares League." Open to the public, the group meets approximately once per month from May through October to play 4-Squares. He has also been working with the Northbridge Play & Recreation Department to have a new 4-Squares court installed at the Linwood Park. "At its core and similar to many other sports such as baseball, 4-Squares is a kids game. Therefore, a passion of mine is to assist in any way I can to ensure our youth have the opportunity to learn and experience this fantastic sport and having a new court installed in town is part of that," Costanza explains.

With COVID restrictions being lifted, the World 4-Squares Championships returned and on May 13, Costanza took the 3 1/2 hour drive north to central Maine. Though, it almost didn't happen as he describes, "My oldest daughter's junior prom was the same day. Therefore, I had already made the decision that I wouldn't miss that. But my daughter urged me to go as long as I win - needless to say, the pressure was on."

At 41, adapting to slight changes of rules, and competing against the majority of other competitors about half his age, Costanza wowed the judges, spectators and fellow players with his assasin-style and won the Men's Division 4-Squares Championships making his

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## Uxbridge H.S. receives National Recognition

Uxbridge High School announced recently that it has been recognized as a 2022-23 Project Lead The Way (PLTW) Distinguished School. It is one of 202 high schools across the U.S. to receive this honor for providing broad access to transformative learning experiences for students through PLTW's computer science, engineering, and biomedical pathways. PLTW is a non-profit organization that serves millions of PreK-12 students and teachers in more than 12,200 schools across the U.S.

"We are proud to have engaged in this partnership for so many of our students. PLTW courses form the framework of so many outstanding learning experiences for our students and school, and it has helped us energize curricula and students engaged in many disciplines."

**• Michael Rubin**  
UXBRIDGE HIGH SCHOOL  
PRINCIPAL

The PLTW Distinguished School recognition honors schools committed to increasing student access, engagement, and achievement in their PLTW programs. To be eligible for the designation, Uxbridge High School had to meet the following criteria in the 2021-22 school year:

### Historical Society Bottle & Can Drive

The Sutton Historical Society will be hosting a bottle/can redemption drive from Saturday, July 8 to Sunday, July 16. Drop off a 24-hour at the M. M. Sherman Blacksmith Shop, 6 Singleary Avenue, Sutton. Simply place your redeemable bottles/cans into the trailer which will be parked alongside the

• Had 25 percent of students or more participate in PLTW courses, or of those who participated in PLTW, at least 33 percent took one or more PLTW courses

• Offer and had students enrolled in at least three PLTW courses

• Have strategies in place that support reasonably proportional representation with regard to race, ethnicity, poverty, and/or gender

"We are proud to recognize Uxbridge High School for their commitment to providing students with exceptional educational experiences while ensuring equitable access to PLTW programs," said Dr. David Dimmett, PLTW President and CEO. "We congratulate them on this achievement and celebrate their important work empowering students with the knowledge and skills to succeed, not only in STEM subjects, but also more generally in life and careers."

This marks the fourth consecutive year that UHS has earned this distinction, one of only a handful of schools in the Commonwealth to have demonstrated this pattern of achievement. Among the programs offered at UHS through PLTW include biomedical science, computer science, engineering, and manufacturing. Many of these courses form the basis of UHS' renowned Innovation Pathways, which serve as a model for many schools in the Commonwealth.

For more information about PLTW's recognition program, visit [pltw.org](http://pltw.org).

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### Southwick's to host Boston 25 Zip Trip

Southwick's Zoo is thrilled to announce its partnership with Boston 25 News to host a Zip Trip on Friday, July 14th. The Zip Trip will take place at the event pavilion located across from the Zoo's main entrance, overlooking the beautiful African Plains.

The event will stream live on television beginning at 6:00 a.m. and will include interviews with Mendon newsmakers, special guests, hometown teams, and local heroes.

Residents of all ages are encouraged to come out and be part of the audience and share what makes their hometown a great place to live.

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local group, town and community proud.

Thinking back to their time together as kids and teenagers, Muradian says of Costanza's accomplishment, "To be perfectly honest, I am not at all surprised. World Champion, yes, but knowing he was successful? Not one bit. Eric was a star athlete for the Northbridge Rams on the baseball diamond, and was a menace (I say that with nothing but admiration) on the 4-Squares court".

4-Squares has not yet become a professional sport which is why it is more commonly referred to as a "game". With the popularity gaining steam, this may be a matter of time as there are negotiations being had to have the event broadcasted on ESPN or one of their affiliated networks next year. When asked why he loves 4-Squares so much, Costanza says, "It's not just a

physical athletic sport. Don't get me wrong, there is a ton of athleticism involved, but there is so much strategy, planning and psychology involved as well." And what about the future of 4-



**Costanza with two of his children at the old Riverdale Park 4-Squares court where he learned the game.**



**Above Eric shares the trophy with his children; Trysta, Desiree and CJ. At right a victorious Costanza with trophy in-hand after winning the World's 4-Squares Championships in Bridgton, Maine.**



Squares? He goes on to say, "I've been saying for over 15 years that 4-Squares should absolutely be an Olympic sport. I know it's looked at as a bit of a quirky and maybe even ridiculous kid game but so wasn't pickle ball once upon a time and look how that's taken off. I see things like corn hole and tag on ESPN and I look forward to the day that 4-Squares get its time to shine and be notarized for the fascinating athletic and strategic sport that it is."

For now, the World Championships is held in Maine, but Muradian would be open to bringing this event to where some consider to be the 4-Squares hub as he excitedly remarks, "Worcester County has so much to offer and helping promote local tourism would certainly be something I would commit to. If Bridgton, Maine decides to stop hosting the event, I can think of no better place to continue the World Championships than right here where the reigning WORLD CHAMPION - ERIC COSTANZA - lives!